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Fitness App Rework



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The Problem

Modern gym applications are useless besides signing in. This interview study aims to gather information on participants gym routines in order to find ways to boost engagement and facilitate a better environment.



Main Research Questions

1

How do participants go about creating and keeping track of their routines?

2

What kind of apps do participants use to assist their gym routines?

3

What kind of improvements would you like to see your gym make?



Research Method

For this study, we decided to go with a semi-structured interview where we asked a total of 8 participants a series of questions including open-ended questions, follow-up questions, and guiding questions

- Number of Participants: 8 participants
- Age ranging from 19-23 years old
- Some are students and some are not students
- All participants attend a gym and have used a fitness app before



Data Analysis

Cluster 1

Motivations & Consistency

Motivation through feeling healthier

Anabhayan

Digital motivational reminders

Anabhayan

Functional Motivation
(e.g., reminders, accuracy)

Ashley Alvarez

Self-Discipline

Ashley Alvarez

Needs gentle nudges, not strict goals

Fayada Adam

Progress tracking

Anabhayan

Positive reinforcement notifications

Anabhayan

Social Motivation (e.g., gym buddy)

Ashley Alvarez

Physical satisfaction as motivation

Ashley Alvarez

Motivated by mental clarity after workouts

Fayada Adam

Motivated by discipline, progress, and structure

Fayada Adam

Fear-based motivation/
Negative reinforcement

Keenan Duncan

Ego-driven motivation

Keenan Duncan

Progress Tracking as Motivation

Ashley Alvarez

Past Traumas as Motivation

Ashley Alvarez

Sees gym as a healing space, not competitive

Fayada Adam

Cluster 2

Pain Points

Lack of existing
gym app at NJIT

Anabhayan

Broken or busy
machines

Anabhayan

Inaccurate
recommendati
ons

Anabhayan

Does not like to be
bombarded with extra
notifications.

Keenan Duncan

Not always motivated

Ashley Alvarez

Different Priorities/hard to
prioritize

Ashley Alvarez

Gym is more enjoyable
when empty for them

Keenan Duncan

Time Constraints

Ashley Alvarez

Learning challenges at the
gym

Ashley Alvarez

Less
interaction
with staff the
better

Keenan Duncan

Features
being free is
a non-
negotiable

Keenan Duncan

Cluster 3

Overall Improvements

Simplified navigation ("one tap")

Anabhayan

Ease of use and user-friendly interface

Anabhayan

Time-based gym suggestions

Anabhayan

Clear design and direct access

Anabhayan

extra features should be free

Keenan Duncan

The QR code based maintenance > front desk complaint

Keenan Duncan

Population meter for gym capacity

Anabhayan

Notifications about crowd levels

Anabhayan

Enjoys features that promote a contactless setup

Keenan Duncan

QR tips and machine guidance

Anabhayan

An app's purpose should be to make things convenient as possible

Keenan Duncan

Gym convenience store credit as an app feature

Keenan Duncan

A sports feature for the app?

Keenan Duncan

Using an AI assistant to provide motivation is dystopian

Keenan Duncan

Learning Support Tools (QR codes with usage tips/form)

Ashley Alvarez

Cluster 4

Habits/Preferences

frequents the gym on a regular basis

Keenan Duncan

Upper, Lower, Cardio Split

Keenan Duncan

prefers to rely on problem solving skills to figure out unfamiliar equipment

Keenan Duncan

prefers to use past experiences to figure out machines

Keenan Duncan

Has a very physically taxing job

Keenan Duncan

Utilizes make up days to stick to goals

Keenan Duncan

Tracks progress mainly on vibes

Keenan Duncan

Utilizes pictures to track progress

Keenan Duncan

Prefers routines tailored to strength vs endurance

Fayada Adam

Very high amount of physical activity

Keenan Duncan

Uses Strong app to track sets and weights

Fayada Adam

Craves personalization that adapts to energy levels

Fayada Adam

Personalization Features

Need for user
personalization

a calendar feature to track
days went is a good idea

Keenan Duncan

personalized
workout plans
based on goals

Fayada Adam

Customizing aesthetics is
not needed but workout
tracking and more
personalization is a
definite add

Keenan Duncan

User control/
customization

Personalized workout
recommendations

Anabhayan

Progress-based feedback

Anabhayan

Desire for Reminders

Daily streaks and motivational
messages would help.

Fayada Adam

Integration with user data
(height, weight, goals)

Anabhayan



Personas



Amy Smith

Amy is a 19 year-old college sophomore majoring in Financial Technology. She loves learning new things and likes to push herself outside of her comfort zone. During her free time, she enjoys going to the gym to stay fit and active.

Personal Information

Age: 19

Major: Financial Technology

Standing: Sophomore

Needs

- A way to organize her workouts in order to maximize efficiency
- A way to stay motivated and consistent
- A way to stay on top of her progress and performance

Goals

- Keep track of her goals and progress
- Stay consistent with her busy schedule
- Wants to stay more organized

Frustrations

- Struggles to stay consistent with her busy schedule
- Her current fitness app feels useless
- Her current workout split is always changing due to lack of organization

"My progress feels stagnant, I wish there was a free solution to track my goals better. "



John Johnson

John is a 21 year-old guy that works at Walmart. John is very committed to his fitness and finds himself in the gym everyday.

Personal Information

Age: 21

Occupation: Retail

Education: High School
Diploma

Needs

- Stay more organized with his workouts
- A way to track progress with new routine
- Better functioning equipment to support him in his fitness journey

Goals

- Switch up his routine and make it more exciting
- Learn calisthenics
- Increase efficiency and time management

Frustrations

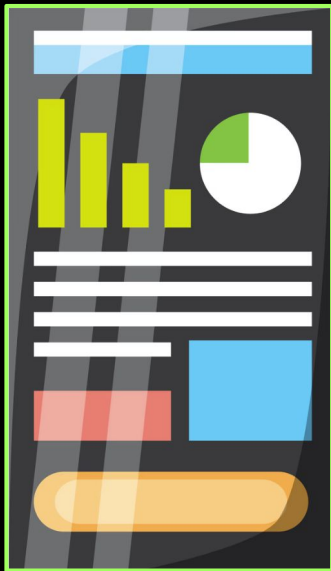
- Salesmen who want to sell him overpriced workout and nutrition plans
- Essential machines always out of order
- Routine is starting to get boring

"I am getting bored of the same routine. I wish there was a way to help me liven up my routine."



Major Themes

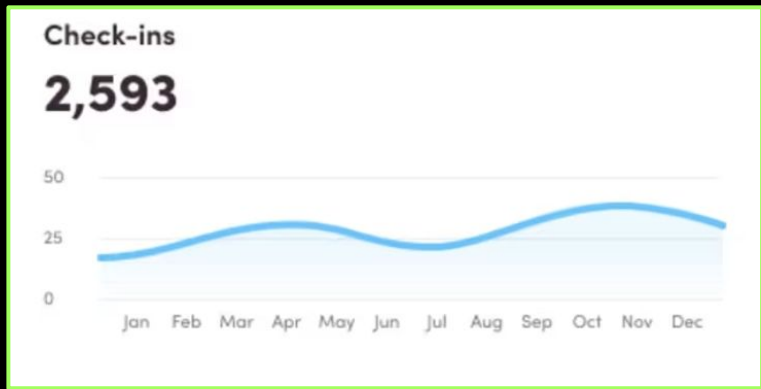
Main Theme	Sub-Themes	Description	Recommended Action
Motivations & Consistency	a. Health and Mental Well-Being b. Discipline and Progress Tracking c. Positive Reinforcement and Supportive Encouragement	Users are motivated by feeling healthier and gaining mental clarity, maintaining consistency through discipline and progress tracking, and preferring gentle, encouraging reminders over strict or fear-based goals.	We should add features that promote flexible goal setting, peer encouragement, and rewards effort.
Pain Points	a. Limited Gym Tech b. Equipment and Environmental Issues c. Motivation, Time, and Preference Constraints	Users face barriers like the lack of a NJIT gym app, broken machines, limited motivation, time constraints, and prefer minimal notifications and staff interaction.	Use technology facilitate a contactless setup that would allow gym users to be more independent.
Overall Improvements	a. Streamlined and Intuitive Design b. Context-Aware and Convenient Features c. Contactless and Supportive Tools	Users want a simple, one-tap interface, real-time insights such as population meters and maintenance alerts, and QR-based tools that make gym visits more convenient, independent, and efficient.	Implement a QR code system on the machines to promote better maintenance, and add a live gym traffic display based on check-in data.
Habits & Preferences	a. Regular Attendance and Structured Routines b. Independent Learning c. Personalized Progress Tracking	Users attend the gym consistently with structured splits, rely on problem-solving and past experience for unfamiliar equipment, and track progress through photos, apps, or adaptive routines.	Less of a need for recommended workouts and machine usage tips, however we must implement a solution like a customizable dashboard that would allow users to keep track of their routines and progress all in one place.
Personalization Features	a. Goal-Oriented and Adaptive Workout Plans b. Progress Tracking and Motivational Feedback c. Integrated and User-Controlled Experience	Users want workouts that adjust to their goals, daily streaks and reminders to maintain engagement, and control over features with integration of personal data for smarter recommendations.	Integration of user data to deliver personalized reminders, encourage consistency through streaks, and near infinite options for customizing the dashboard.



Solution 1: Personalized Dashboard

- Most fitness apps feel useless
- Participants want easier way to track performance, workouts, and progress
- Giving users the opportunity to personalize their dashboard based on their needs and goals would help improve gym attendance, user engagement, and improve motivation and consistency.
- Drag drop widgets right onto the homescreen.
- Example widgets: Splits, sets/reps tracker, recommended workouts, etc.





Solution 2: Consistency Streaks and Attendance Insights

- Some participants have trouble building consistency and staying motivated.
- This would help motivate people to keep up their streaks as well as take a bird's eye view of what their attendance looks like week to week, or month to month.
- This would be a widget you could add to the dashboard.
- We could also leverage this to track current gym attendance to in order to know if the gym is crowded or empty currently.



Solution 3: QR Code Based Maintenance

- Broken machines halt the flow of the workout because now you must find a new replacement exercise.
- Most people aren't reporting broken equipment because they can't seem to find staff, or pessimism that it won't get fixed anyway.
- This would make the process streamlined (30 seconds max), and restore confidence in the maintenance staff.
- Just scan and fill out a form. Data is stored so complaints won't be forgotten.

